

his deathbed. However, soon after his victory at the Milvian Bridge, he began the process of rehabilitating, and then exalting, Christianity; in 313 CE, he issued the Edict of Milan, a proclamation that established religious toleration for Christianity within the empire.

A multi-faith empire

For almost 300 years after the life of Jesus Christ, the religion based on his teachings remained a minor sect within the Roman Empire, practiced alongside many other faiths, both mono- and polytheistic. Some aspects of Christianity, such as its egalitarian nature, made it suspicious to the imperial authorities, however, and Christians were periodically persecuted.

All across the ancient world at this time, changing social, political, and economic conditions were reflected in cultural and religious changes; Christianity was just one of a number of monotheisms gaining popularity in the Roman Empire, including the Persian cult of Mithraism, with which it had much in common.

The rise of Christianity

In 324, after disposing of the emperor in the East, Constantine became sole ruler of the Roman Empire, and then sought to use Christianity as a unifying force across his diverse and fractious realm. To make the increasingly dominant eastern half easier to govern, he founded a new city called Constantinople (now Istanbul), consecrating it with both Christian and pagan rites, but allowing only Christian churches to be built. Although it would take time for all Roman citizens to convert to Christianity, in Constantine's reign, the higher ranks of society, seeking political advancement and personal favor with the emperor, flocked to the Church, and the emperor built basilicas across the empire.

Christianity, however, was not a single, uniform religion at this time, and splits, or schisms, formed. In 325, Constantine convened the Council of Nicaea—the first universal council of the Christian Church—mainly to settle the Arian schism, a theological dispute over whether Jesus was of the same substance as God.

Roman emperors derive authority and legitimacy from **pagan religions**.



Christianity's egalitarianism threatens to **disrupt the strict social order** of the Roman Empire.



Constantine sees Christianity, with its one supreme deity, as a **tool for unity**, and a **validation of imperial authority**.



After the Battle of Milvian Bridge, Constantine adopts Christianity. It later becomes the official religion of the Roman Empire.



The Church is refashioned in the image of the **Roman state**, with a **strict hierarchy** and **centralization of dogma**.

Rome is Christianized

In the mid-300s, Emperor Julian, an adherent of the old religion, tried to revive paganism, but it was too late: Christians had become a majority, at least in the East. The faith was increasingly bound up with empire, as the Roman state adopted and molded the Church into an instrument of social and political control, unity, and stability.

Under Emperor Theodosius I (reigned 379–395), pagan temples and cults were suppressed, heresy was outlawed, and Christianity became the official religion of the Roman Empire. Eventually, it also became the faith of the barbarian successor states in the Roman Western Empire, as well as of the Byzantine Empire in the East. Over the course of many centuries, the western (Catholic) and eastern (Orthodox) churches grew apart in doctrine and organization, but Christianity endured. ■